‘Polytheism’ in Ancient World Religions: Egyptian, Babylonian, Greek and Roman Religions[1]

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Abstract

When scrutinizing human history, from prehistoric period up to present time, the role played by religion in the lives of the human beings is alluring. It is clear that from the very beginning, people have practiced religion in some form everywhere in the world. Polytheism or the belief in many gods is a notion we can identify in many ancient religions around the world. As this study examines the ancient religions of Egypt, Babylonia, Greece and Rome, the findings prove the fact that though the names differ from each culture, the way these nations have identified different gods and goddesses representing different aspects such as elements of nature, human emotions, desires etc. shows similarities.

Keywords: ancient world religions, divinity, elements of nature, similarity

1. Introduction

When defining what religion is, Braden (1954) presents two approaches “as the ‘what’ approach and the ‘why’. One defines religion in terms of the attitudes and relationships involved in religious behavior, the other in terms of the motivation underlying such behavior”. According to Greer (2005) it is impossible for us to “experience the world, even for an instant, without experiencing it through some myth, some narrative structure that sorts out our experiences and gives them meaning to us.”

While some religions have risen and flourished, there can be numerous religions which have faded away without leaving traces for us to refer. Most of the ancient religions of the world are disclosed through the archeological excavations such as the ancient religions of Greece, Egypt and Babylonia. When studying the origin of religion in human mind, most of the scholars agree

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to the fact that it has originated due to the "attempts man made to adjust himself to the world in which he found himself, a world so strange, so perplexing, so dangerous, so destructive, yet withal so good" (Braden, 1954, p.21). The ancient man lived in a world quite different from the modern world that we perceive today. Though the things they needed were in abundance, the access for them was not easy: they had to toil amidst all the dangers of the world to get them. The man felt feeble and helpless and felt that nature and its elements are out of man's control to be tamed. That may be the reason behind for some to believe that the base of religion is fear.

Ancient religion at the stage of 'animism' was a period when people believed that spirits of good and evil dwelled in certain objects of nature. Gradually the man of the primitive age invented methods to control those spirits by cajoling them. Gifts were offered to win the blessings of the good spirits while offerings were to be made to appease the anger of the evil spirits. It is such activities which were later developed to sacrifices, rituals and ceremonies and as Braden (1954) further explains, "At first there were probably no specially designated individuals for performing the ritual… but as it became more and more complex, a special class, the priesthood emerged".

It is to fulfill the earnest needs of man that religion arises and the requirements of the man of the primitive age were basically physical such as food to live, shelter for protection and fertility for the ongoing of the tribes. Therefore, his "religion has to do with the hunt, the chase, the weapons and tools that he uses, the food that he eats, the rude shelter that protects him from the elements, the wars by which he defends himself…" (Braden, 1954, p.23). The man of the primitive age worshipped the nature powers; the sky, the sun, the moon, wind, water, stars, mountains, trees, springs, ocean etc. When he cultured with time, these needs expanded to the level of moral and spiritual, but never lost the place given for physical needs. This advancement changed 'animism' to 'polytheism'; the belief in the spirits changed to the veneration of gods and goddesses. There are numerous instances in the history of ancient world religions, how people have attributed divinity to the elements of nature and given them names. When analyzing the 'polytheism' in the ancient civilizations, it is clear that it is only the names of divinity which are different, whereas their functions as well as the rites and rituals performed on behalf of them, show striking similarities.

2. Objectives

The study seeks to achieve the following objectives:

a) To examine the concept of polytheism in the ancient world religions

b) To identify the similarities in the divinity with regard to their functions as well as rites and rituals

3. Methodology

This study is a textual analysis and utilizes several renowned books and articles written on the subject matter. The study extracts necessary instances and examples in the analysis of the study.

4. Discussion

In most of the ancient civilizations of the world, religion is woven around polytheism; group of gods and goddesses representing different powers and elements of nature. In the ancient civilizations of Babylon, Egypt, Mesopotamia, Incas and Mayas of America, Greece, Rome and Peru, we are able to identify polytheism in their religions and such a study, paves the way to identify the similarities and differences of those ancient religions practiced in different civilizations. According to the explanation of Assman (2007) on polytheism, "although polytheistic religions include a concept of divine unity, these religions undoubtedly do worship a plethora of gods, which justifies applying a word built on the element poly (many) to them. Unity in this case does not mean the exclusive worship of one god, but the structure and coherence of the divine world, which is not just an accumulation of deities, but a structured whole, a pantheon". According to Greer (2005) "to worship different gods is to align oneself with different ideals, and to embrace different moral standards".

In ancient Egypt, there have been independent city states called 'nomes' with their own government and its local god or gods. "The country's external and internal success was accredited to their influence and support, and in each dynasty the rulers would select a particular god as their own royal patron and protector" (Hinnels, 2007, p.81). When one city state dominates another, its god also considered as superior to the god of the subjugated city. Sometimes both gods were worshipped and there were instances when the two were worshipped together by hyphenating their names. "All of the major deities are lords or ladies of a town, and all of the major towns or cities are the realms of specific deities. The institution of divine rulership served as a representation of social and political identity" (Assmann & Frankfurter, 2007, p.156). The chief god of Lower Egypt was Horus of Behdet while Set of

Ombos was the main god of Upper Egypt. As these two kingdoms were bitter enemies of each other, even god Horus and god Set were considered as rivals, Horus being the sun of light and Set the god of darkness. Therefore, after years, even when the political conflict between the two cities was over, the two gods were still regarded as enemies. In ancient Egypt during the early period, the gods were usually represented as animals; "Amon of Thebes was a ram, Sebek was a crocodile, Thoth was a baboon or an ibis, Hathor of Dendera was a cow, Bast was a cat, Sekhmet of Memphis was a lioness, Apis was a bull" (Braden, 1954. p.45). Though this group of gods was physically animals, they were regarded not as animals but as persons and later in time they were portrayed with human body and an animal head.

As Braden (1954) explains further, the priests have had a hard time attempting to bring order to this "confusing mass of gods". First attempt has been to put them into family relationships such as father, mother and son. Consequently, the grouping has been done by making Amon, the principal god; Mut, the mother; and Khons, the moon god as son. But the triad which has played a major role in Egypt for a longer period was Osiris, Isis and Horus. Hinnels (2007) also supports this notion stating that the "Egyptians believed that creation had been brought about through divine thoughts and words. During the Old Kingdom, when the priests attempted to rationalize the worship of a multiplicity of gods whose cults had come into existence in earlier times, they arranged them into groups or families". Even in the ancient Egypt as in most of the ancient civilizations of the world, apart from the local animal gods, the great nature powers such as the sky, the sun, the moon, the Nile etc. were assigned divinity and worshipped. Out of the efforts on establishing one god instead of the many, it was only during the period of Amenhotep IV that god Aton made the only god but only for a brief period and the people got back to their former beliefs on polytheism.

As explained by Assmann & Frankfurter (2007), the Egyptians believed that "all of the gods cooperate in the project of maintaining the world, of keeping the cosmic process going. The core of this process is constituted by what the ancient Egyptians conceived of as the solar circuit, the daily course of the sun across the heavens and through the netherworld".

Even in Babylonia it could be observed that polytheism is visible as in ancient Egypt. As explained by Oppnheim (1964), the evidence for ancient Mesopotamian religion "is archeological as well as textual. The archeological evidence consists of the remnants of buildings and structures that served cult purposes such as shrines, temples, and temple towers,

and of objects of worship, in the widest sense of this term, from images to charms". In Babylonia as it was in Egypt, certain gods won supremacy due to the political stability of the cities but in contrast, animal worship was not regarded as important. Babylonia was segregated into city-states and each had their god or gods who were regarded as the guardian of the city while the ruler of each state was considered as the priest of the cult. "In Lagash, Ningirsu was the patron god; in Eridu it was Ea; in Nippur it was Enlil or Bel; in Ur it was Sin" (Braden, 1954, p.51). When wars occurred between cities, some gods became supreme in the defeated city-states. Some local gods were worshipped even beyond the city limits and were "identified with the heavenly bodies; thus Shamash of Agade was a sun god; Ishtar was identified with the planet Venus" (Braden, 1954, p.51).

The triad of Ea, Enlil and Anu can be identified at the early period in Babylonia and were believed to be ruling the universe together. They were regarded as supreme to the local deities and early mythology and religion centered about the triad. Ea was the ruler of water on and under the earth while Enlil ruled the earth and the surrounded atmosphere. Anu was regarded as the ruler of the sky or heaven. The second triad which came prominent later consisted of Shamash, Sin and Ishtar. Shamash was the god of sun who later became the supreme judge of the world, Sin was the moon god and Ishtar was the fertility god (there were instances when he was displaced by Adad, the storm god in the triad).

In ancient Greece also we find polytheism and gods representing elements of nature as well as emotions and desires. In the Greek world, the deities were anthropomorphic and the Greeks believed that they dwelt on the Olympus Mountain. As Gibbon (1990) explains these Greek gods "did not impose a code of moral behavior which they demanded humans should follow. But they did demand recognition of their power, and they would respond to due sacrifice and prayer". The Olympic pantheon reigned by the great god Zeus and the rest of the gods and goddesses were the ultimate representation of power for the ancient Greeks. As in most of the other ancient civilizations, Greeks also believed that their gods and goddesses represented the natural objects and also human emotions. They were of the strong belief that these gods protected them and guided them in all their endeavors. "Beside the major divinities revered all over Greece, there were the many gods who had special functions or exercised power over a local district or family" (Starr, 1980, p.28). Therefore, throughout the Greek world also we witness the notion of polytheism, as they worshipped numerous deities.

Zeus, the god of sky and the father of gods and humans ruled from the Olympus with the aid of other gods and goddesses. The Goddess of women and motherhood Hera (sister and wife of Zeus), God of war Ares, Goddess of agriculture and fertility Demeter, God of Light, Reason, Inspiration, Intellect, Arts, Healing, and Prophecy Apollo, goddess of Crafts and Wisdom Athena (patron goddess of Athens), God of Trade and Communication Hermes (divine messenger), Goddess of Moon, Wildwood and Beasts Artemis, God of Sea and Earthquakes Poseidon, Goddess of Fire Hestia, God of Craft and Divine Smith Hephaestus, Goddess of love and beauty Aphrodite, God of Drama, Wild Nature, Fertility, Ecstasy and Wine Dionysus or Bacchus, God of Death and Underworld Hades or Pluto, God of Woodlands Pan, God of love Eros and God of Agriculture Kronos were the deities that the ancient Greeks venerated. "The total list of gods is endless. The great gods came to be thought of as twelve…" (Braden, 1954, p.58).

According to Braden (1954), "while the religions of Rome and Greece in the later periods were very similar, and they seemed to worship the same gods" in earlier periods, Romans have had their own unique set of deities. Early Romans unlike the Greeks identified their gods not as persons, but as animistic; numerous spirits on whom they believed that their entire lives depended on. "There were the Lares or guardians of the fields and later of the whole household; the Penates, keepers of the storeroom; Vesta, the hearth spirit; Janus, guardian of the doors… forty-three gods presided over separate phases of childhood development" (Braden, 1954, p.64). Thus it is clear that even in the religion of Rome, the numerous deities have been worshipped. As history unveils, they didn't have temples constructed for the deities, not represented by images or no priests appointed for the rites and rituals. Head of the family had performed the rites at home and before meals, they have placed some food in the fire as a sacrifice to Vesta. Later, the Romans identified most of the Greek gods and goddesses in their Roman names. Greek god Zeus was identified as Jupiter in the Roman world Hera as Juno. God of war Ares was identified as Mars, Goddess of agriculture and fertility Demeter was named as Ceres in Rome. God of Intellect, Arts, Healing, and Prophecy Apollo was regarded in the same name Apollo while the goddess of Crafts and Wisdom Athena was named as Minerva. God of Trade and Communication Hermes was called Mercury, Goddess of Moon, Wildwood and Beasts Artemis was named Diana, God of Sea Poseidon was named as Neptune, Goddess of Fire Hestia was known as Vesta, God of Craft and Divine Smith Hephaestus was named as Vulcan, Goddess of love and beauty Aphrodite was known as Venus, God of Drama, Fertility, Ecstasy and Wine Dionysus or Bacchus was called Liber, God of Death and

Underworld Hades or Pluto was known as Dis Pater, God of Woodlands Pan was named as Faunus, God of love Eros was known as Cupid and God of Agriculture was called Saturn in the Roman world.

5. Conclusion

Champdor (1958) states "the gods were imagined in human form and endowed with human emotions and desires. The temple was therefore quite literally the house of the god where he dwelt in the person of his statue, and had to be clothed and fed". When examining ancient cultures around the world, it is clear that human beings have identified numerous gods and goddesses and have even gifted them human shape as well as human emotions while temples were built for them to dwell. In the Egyptian, Babylonian, Greek and Roman ancient religions we can identify the notion of polytheism as they all believe in not one god, but many gods representing different aspects of the world. Thus it is clear that though the names differ from each other due to the fact that they are separate kingdoms, in the Egyptian, Babylonian, Greek and Roman ancient religions, the gods and goddesses represent elements of nature as well as emotions and desires.

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